The second caveat on India's ability to construct a robust defence is related to the point just made, namely, its massive dependence on foreign weapon systems. The Indian defence industry does not produce a single major conventional armament, with the partial exception of naval vessels. Automatic rifles and artillery, combat aircraft, helicopters, and transport planes, and even most of its naval vessels are imported or made under licence. The only systems that are largely indigenously designed and produced are nuclear weapons and missiles. Why so? Because no one will sell these to India. They are so-called strategic weapons – because of their decisive nature in war – and no one, not even allies, are prone to share them. They therefore had to be produced at home. When the crisis with China in the summer of 2020 deepened, India's nervousness over its conventional forces was evident. In June, India's defence minister, Rajnath Singh, went to Russia to participate in its Victory Day celebrations, but the larger purpose was to ensure that Moscow fulfilled its contracts with India for the delivery of the S-400 missiles and spare parts for India's Russian-made aircraft, tanks, and helicopters. While Russia promised to honour its commitments, the question that hung in the air was: what would happen in the case of an India–China war given Moscow's close relations with Beijing?

The third caveat on India's military capacities relates to nuclear weapons. As argued earlier, Chinese advantages in conventional weapons could be offset not just by geography and appropriate conventional defence, they could also be compensated for by nuclear weapons. Yet, India's resort to nuclear weapons must face the same challenge that Pakistan faces in nuclearizing the battlefield. It has been argued by Indian strategists that Islamabad is unlikely to use nuclear weapons against larger Indian forces because India has 'escalation dominance' – Delhi can 'up the ante' and increase the level of violence beyond anything that Pakistan can throw at it including nuclear weapons (though now that Pakistan is reported to have more nuclear weapons than India, this may no longer be a sustainable argument). The problem for India in a conflict with China is that the